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AUDRE LORDE
1934–1992

Acclaimed essayist, poet, and feminist theorist, Audre Lorde was born Audrey Geraldine Lorde to West Indian parents in Harlem, New York, in 1934. In *Zami: A New Spelling of My Name* (1982), Lorde explained why, at age four, she chose to rename herself: "I did not like the tail of the Y hanging down below the line in Audrey, and would always forget to put it on, which used to disturb my mother greatly." This childhood act of self-determination presages the themes and motifs that characterize much of Lorde's later poetry and nonfiction—the struggle for self-expression in a society that considers difference to be subversive and suspect. In *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches* (1984), Lorde refutes the belief that difference can at best be merely tolerated by society; instead, she writes, difference is an energizing charge, "a fund of necessary polarities between which our creativity can spark." A self-described "Black lesbian mother warrior poet" who played significant roles in the civil rights, feminist, and LGBT movements—and who was among the first public figures to speak openly of her experience of breast cancer—Lorde embraced her "differences" as inspiration for generative insight and expressive power.

As her self-naming suggests, Lorde's childhood and educational experiences were integral to her development as a poet and theorist. Lorde confessed that, as a child, she had difficulty learning to speak in complete sentences, expressing herself instead through the poems and poetic fragments she had memorized. She attended Catholic elementary schools in New York City and, while still in high school, published her first poem in *Seventeen* magazine because the editors of her school's literary journal deemed her submission inappropriately romantic. This uneasy relation to self-appointed custodians of official literary expression extended to Lorde's experience of sophisticated black culture in New York, as she found when occasionally taking part during her Hunter High years in poetry workshops sponsored by the prestigious Harlem Writers Guild. "There had been a very uneasy dialogue between me and the Harlem Writers Guild where I felt I was tolerated but never really accepted—that I was both crazy and queer but would grow out of it all." The social challenges of Lorde's fledgling literary career foretell a lifelong quest to find partners for a dialogue in which acceptance could be achieved without compromise of personhood or principle.

After completing high school, she enrolled at the National University of Mexico in 1954 for one year, which she later identified as one of the transformative experiences of her life. In a land of greater racial, social, and intellectual variety than she experienced in 1950s America, Lorde was struck by a revelation of "connectedness" that would beckon to her in subsequent years of continued alienation: "I stood on this hill, halfway down to the market, and for the first time in that one instant I felt that I could make a connection—that there could be a real connection between the things that I felt most deeply and those gorgeous words that I needed to spin in order to live . . . And for one minute I thought 'I can write a poem that feels like this.'" Lorde's vision in Mexico, and particularly its ideal of fitting words to life, would linger in her consciousness as a creatively disruptive alternative to the life she would soon take up again as an evidently conventional New Yorker pursuing the life of an educated aspirant to middle-class respectability.

Upon returning to New York, Lorde earned her B.A. in English and Philosophy from Hunter College in 1959, and received her M.A. from the Columbia University School of Library Science in 1961. During the 1950s she had been employed intermittently as an x-ray technician and factory laborer; she worked as a librarian during

the 1960s, eventually attaining the position of head librarian of the Town School Library from 1966 to 1968.

The turbulent period of the late 1960s were also pivotal years for Lorde's burgeoning career as poet. In 1968 Diane Di Prima, whom Lorde had met at Hunter College, published Lorde's first collection of poems, *The First Cities.* In fact, her reputation as a poet preceded this publication, for she received the first copies of *The First Cities* while serving as poet-in-residence at Tougaloo College, a small historically black college in Mississippi. There, amidst the growing turmoil of the civil rights movement, Lorde formed a poetry workshop composed of approximately ten undergraduates, most of whom were black, militant, and eager to discuss the era's pressing issues of race and social justice. As with her sojourn in Mexico, her work at Tougaloo initiated for Lorde a radical reevaluation of her personal and professional priorities. "It was pivotal for me because in 1968 my first book had just been published; it was my first trip into the Deep South; it was the first time I had been away from my children. It was the first time I dealt with young black students in a workshop situation. I came to realize that this was my work, that teaching and writing were inextricably combined, and it was there that I knew what I wanted to do for the rest of my life." This epiphany was equally about poetry as a discipline and life as a mission. Both literary vocation and lived experience seemed to her a blank page, daunting but thrilling. "Formally, I knew nothing. I had never read a book *about* poetry! So I would talk to the students, and I was learning." Aptly titled *Cables to Rage,* the book of poems Lorde wrote during the Tougaloo period blended Lorde's increasing attention to poetic craft with an urgency to live the truth of her "crazy and queer" identity. It was at Tougaloo that she met her female lover, Frances Clayton, who would accompany Lorde on the extraordinary artistic path that now stretched before her.

Lorde would publish nine subsequent volumes of poetry: *From a Land Where Other People Live* (1973), which was nominated for the National Book Award; *New York Head Shop and Museum* (1974); *Coal* (1976); *Between Ourselves* (1976); *The Black Unicorn* (1978); *Chosen Poems: Old and New* (1982); *Our Dead behind Us* (1986); *Undersong: Chosen Poems Old and New* (1992); and the posthumous *The Marvelous Arithmetics of Distance* (1993). In each collection, Lorde explored her complex identity, which she would later term her "consciousness as a woman, a black lesbian feminist mother lover poet all I am," and interrogated American homophobia, imperialism, and racism with unrelenting acuity and candor. She was awarded the Walt Whitman Citation of Merit in 1991, making her the poet laureate of New York State.

With the release of *Coal* in 1976, Lorde became an influential voice among Black Arts writers, though her relation to the movement was always complex. In that context, it is tempting to read the title poem's images of coal and diamond as metaphors for a purified blackness, but Lorde characteristically undermines any such essentialist oversimplification with a continual shifting of subject positions, a self-reflexive rumination on the very act of symbolization that embodies the poem's early claim that "there are many kinds of open." This intricate openness constitutes a central theme of her next collection of poems, *The Black Unicorn,* an effort to ahieve an expansive ideal of identity with a richer range of mythic, social, and linguistic resources. Drawing upon African creation stories, with their compelling pantheon of female divinities, Lorde begins to fashion her own version of pan-Africanism that at once augments and challenges those of many Black Arts era artists and activists. If for writers like Baraka and Reed, African cosmologies furnished a repetoire of bold male gods capable of forging and defending an aboriginal black universe, for Lorde that warrior ethos is transferred to a female vangard capable equally of force and fertility. Emblemized in the amazonian heroine (whose self-sacrifice of one breast in the service of military prowess resonated with Lorde's own struggle with breast cancer), Lorde's africanicity inflects gender and sexuality in terms that oppose the masculinist ethos prevalent among many male writers of the period, though it aims no less at a reimagined "blackness" capable of fierce yet loving communal identity. But for Lorde such "blackness" becomes not a privileged

but a companion figure, sharing space and authority with other dimensions of selfhood in Lorde's vision of ancestrally founded consciousness.

Though Lorde once remarked that "communicating deep feeling in linear, solid blocks of print felt arcane, a method beyond me," she is widely recognized for her nonfiction prose. *The Cancer Journals* (1980) is part confession, part polemic; it chronicles the diagnosis and treatment of and her recovery from breast cancer even as it inveighs against cultural norms of physical beauty that "encourage" postoperative breast cancer patients to conceal their new "deformities" with prostheses. Lorde would once again reflect on the effects of cancer on her life in *A Burst of Light* (1988), a collage of essays and journal entries that won an American Book Award in 1989. Lorde's *Zami: A New Spelling of My Name* (1982) is likewise a remarkable literary feat that seamlessly blends memoir, myth, and poetry. A record of her childhood and early adulthood, *Zami* is an often poignant, often didactic, but always emotionally raw narrative of sexual self-awareness and of the friendships forged among marginalized black women. In the highly influential anthology *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches* (1984), Lorde insists that those whom society has marginalized must communicate their experiences and render visible, however painfully, what society endeavors to repress.

Lorde's activism and political vision, however, were not confined to her poetry and prose writings. She taught at Hunter College, at Lehman College, and at John Jay College; lectured widely on racism and on homophobia; co-founded The Kitchen Table: Women of Color Press; and was a featured speaker at the first national gay and lesbian march held in Washington, D.C., in 1979. She also worked tirelessly to mobilize women across the African diaspora, establishing the St. Croix Women's Coalition and the Sisterhood in Support of Sisters in South Africa.

Seven years before her death, Lorde relocated to the Caribbean, where she adopted the African name Gamba Adisa, expressing her dedication to Pan-Africanism. There, she prepared a final volume of poetry, *Undersong: Chosen Poems Old and New* (1992). That year, at the age of fifty-eight, she succumbed to liver cancer at her home on St. Croix. In considering her complex legacy, we might do best by recalling Lorde's reflection on her poetry's effort to revisit our inheritances of thought and feeling: "The white fathers told us: I think, therefore I am. The Black mother within each of us—the poet—whispers in our dreams: I feel, therefore I can be free. Poetry coins the language to express and charter this revolutionary demand, the implementation of that freedom."

Following her death, virtually every major U.S. journal and newspaper eulogized Lorde, and women across the United States, Europe, and the Caribbean held tributes in her honor. In the November 20, 1992, edition of the *Boston Globe*, columnist Renee Graham praised Lorde's sparkling lyricism and emotional register: "With words spun into light, she could weep like Billie Holiday, chuckle like Dizzy Gillespie, or bark bad like John Coltrane."

New York City 1970

How do you spell change like frayed slogan underwear
with the emptied can of yesterdays' meanings
with yesterdays' names?
And what does the we-bird see with
who has lost its I's? 5

There is nothing beautiful left in the streets of this city.
I have come to believe in death and renewal by fire.[1]

1. In classical mythology, the phoenix, later also called the firebird, was an eagle-like bird that was consumed by a funeral pyre ignited by the sun, only to renew itself from its own ashes for another long cycle of life.

who bomb my children into mortar in churches[7]
and work plastic offal and metal and the flesh of their enemies
into subway rush-hour temples where obscene priests
finger and worship each other in secret 50
and think they are praying when they squat
to shit money-pebbles shaped like their parents' brains—
who exist to go into dust to exist again
grosser and more swollen and without ever relinquishing
space or breath or energy from their private hoard. 55

I do not need to make war nor peace
with these prancing and murderous deacons[8]
who refuse to recognize their role in this covenant[9] we live upon
and so have come to fear and despise even their own children;
but I condemn myself, and my loves 60
past and present
and the blessed enthusiasms of all my children
to this city
without reason or future
without hope 65
to be tried as the new steel is tried
before trusted to slaughter.

I walk down the withering limbs of my last discarded house
and there is nothing worth salvage left in this city
but the faint reedy voices like echoes 70
of once beautiful children.[1]

1970

Coal

I
Is the total black, being spoken
From the earth's inside.
There are many kinds of open.
How a diamond comes into a knot of flame[1] 5
How a sound comes into a word, coloured
By who pays what for speaking.[2]

7. On September 15, 1963, in an act of white supremacist terrorism, the 16th Street Baptist Church in Birmingham, Alabama was bombed, killing four young girls. The bombing immediately became a critical moment and powerful symbol in the civil rights struggle.
8. Lay preachers, given biblical sanction in 1 Timothy 3.8: "Likewise must the deacons be grave, not doubletongued, not given much to wine, not greedy of filthy lucre."
9. Solemn agreement; in biblical terms, one that links entrance into a community with a promise to God of faith, and links God to the community in a pledge of care and perpetual inheritance of the promised land.

1. Cf. the Old Testament's Book of Lamentations, which mourns the destruction of Jerusalem and the Holy Temple in the 6th century B.C.E.: "Her [Jerusalem's] adversaries are the chief, her enemies prosper; for the Lord hath afflicted her for the multitude of her transgressions: her children are gone into captivity before the enemy" (Lamentations 1.5).
1. Like coal, diamonds are produced after great pressure and heat are applied to carbon, though diamonds are created over billions of years, coal over millions, under differing natural conditions.
2. In the Bible's Book of Isaiah, a heavenly being touches the prophet's mouth with a cleansing coal (6.6–7).

Some words are open
Like a diamond on glass windows
Singing out within the crash of passing sun 10
Then there are words like stapled wagers
In a perforated book—buy and sign and tear apart—
And come whatever wills all chances
The stub remains
An ill-pulled tooth with a ragged edge. 15
Some words live in my throat
Breeding like adders.[3] Others know sun
Seeking like gypsies over my tongue
To explode through my lips
Like young sparrows bursting from shell. 20
Some words
Bedevil me.

Love is a word another kind of open—
As a diamond comes into a knot of flame
I am black because I come from the earth's inside 25
Take my word for jewel in your open light.

1976

Power

The difference between poetry and rhetoric
is being ready to kill
yourself
instead of your children.

I am trapped on a desert of raw gunshot wounds 5
and a dead child dragging his shattered
black face off the edge of my sleep
blood from his punctured cheeks and shoulders
is the only liquid for miles and my stomach
churns at the imagined taste while 10
my mouth splits into dry lips
without loyalty or reason
thirsting for the wetness of his blood
as it sinks into the whiteness
of the desert where I am lost 15
without imagery or magic
trying to make power
out of hatred and destruction
trying to heal my dying son with kisses
only the sun will bleach his bones quicker. 20

3. Snakes (traditionally considered demonic).

The policeman who shot down a ten year old in Jamaica[1]
stood over the boy with his cop shoes in childish blood
and a voice said "Die you little motherfucker"[2] and
there are tapes to prove that.
At his trial this policeman said in his own defense 25
"I didn't notice the size or anything else
only the color," and
there are tapes to prove that too.

Today that 37 year old white man with 13 years of police forcing
was set free 30
by 11 white men who said they were satisfied
justice had been done
and one black woman who said "They convinced me"[3]
meaning
they had dragged her 4′10″ black woman's frame 35
over the hot coals of four centuries of white male approval
until she let go of the first real power she ever had
and lined her own womb with cement
to make a graveyard for our children.

I have not been able to touch the destruction within me 40
but unless I learn to use
the difference between poetry and rhetoric
my power too will run corrupt as poisonous mold
or lie limp and useless as an unconnected wire
and one day I will take my teenaged plug 45
and connect it to the nearest socket
raping some 85 year old white woman
and as I beat her senseless and set a torch to her bed
a greek chorus will be singing in ¾ time[4]
"Poor thing. She never hurt a soul. What beasts they are." 50

1976

Poetry Is Not a Luxury

The quality of light by which we scrutinize our lives has direct bearing upon the product which we live, and upon the changes which we hope to bring about through those lives. It is within this light that we form those ideas by which we pursue our magic and make it realized. This is poetry as illumination, for it is through poetry that we give name to those ideas which

1. On April 28, 1973, a ten-year-old black boy named Clifford Glover was shot in the back while running away from New York police officer Thomas Shea in the South Jamaica section of the borough of Queens. On June 12 Shea was indicted on a charge of murder and, after a lengthy trial, was acquitted by a jury of eleven white men and one African American woman, Ederica Campbell.
2. At the crime scene, an obscene remark uttered by a police officer was inadvertently transmitted over police radio.
3. After the trial, when another juror inadvertently revealed her as the one who had held out against acquittal the longest, Campbell stated, "They almost killed me, and I almost killed them."
4. Musical time signature or meter; "greek chorus": in classical drama, a group of characters, usually representing and often played by citizens, who typically offer judgments about a play's protagonists.

are—until the poem—nameless and formless, about to be birthed, but already felt. That distillation of experience from which true poetry springs births thought as dream births concept, as feeling births idea, as knowledge births (precedes) understanding.

As we learn to bear the intimacy of scrutiny and to flourish within it, as we learn to use the products of that scrutiny for power within our living, those fears which rule our lives and form our silences begin to lose their control over us.

For each of us as women, there is a dark place within, where hidden and growing our true spirit rises, "beautiful / and tough as chestnut / stanchions against (y)our nightmare of weakness /"[1] and of impotence.

These places of possibility within ourselves are dark because they are ancient and hidden; they have survived and grown strong through that darkness. Within these deep places, each one of us holds an incredible reserve of creativity and power, of unexamined and unrecorded emotion and feeling. The woman's place of power within each of us is neither white nor surface; it is dark, it is ancient, and it is deep.

When we view living in the european mode only as a problem to be solved, we rely solely upon our ideas to make us free, for these were what the white fathers told us were precious.

But as we come more into touch with our own ancient, noneuropean consciousness of living as a situation to be experienced and interacted with, we learn more and more to cherish our feelings, and to respect those hidden sources of our power from where true knowledge and, therefore, lasting action comes.

At this point in time, I believe that women carry within ourselves the possibility for fusion of these two approaches so necessary for survival, and we come closest to this combination in our poetry. I speak here of poetry as a revelatory distillation of experience, not the sterile word play that, too often, the white fathers distorted the word *poetry* to mean—in order to cover a desperate wish for imagination without insight.

For women, then, poetry is not a luxury. It is a vital necessity of our existence. It forms the quality of the light within which we predicate our hopes and dreams toward survival and change, first made into language, then into idea, then into more tangible action. Poetry is the way we help give name to the nameless so it can be thought. The farthest horizons of our hopes and fears are cobbled by our poems, carved from the rock experiences of our daily lives.

As they become known to and accepted by us, our feelings and the honest exploration of them become sanctuaries and spawning grounds for the most radical and daring of ideas. They become a safe-house for that difference so necessary to change and the conceptualization of any meaningful action. Right now, I could name at least ten ideas I would have found intolerable or incomprehensible and frightening, except as they came after dreams and poems. This is not idle fantasy, but a disciplined attention to the true meaning of "it feels right to me." We can train ourselves to respect our feelings and to transpose them into a language so they can be shared. And where that language does not yet exist, it is our poetry which helps to fashion it. Poetry is not only dream and vision; it is the skeleton architecture of

1. From Lorde's 1973 poem "Black Mother Woman."

our lives. It lays the foundations for a future of change, a bridge across our fears of what has never been before.

Possibility is neither forever nor instant. It is not easy to sustain belief in its efficacy. We can sometimes work long and hard to establish one beachhead of real resistance to the deaths we are expected to live, only to have that beachhead assaulted or threatened by those canards we have been socialized to fear, or by the withdrawal of those approvals that we have been warned to seek for safety. Women see ourselves diminished or softened by the falsely benign accusations of childishness, of nonuniversality, of changeability, of sensuality. And who asks the question: Am I altering your aura, your ideas, your dreams, or am I merely moving you to temporary and reactive action? And even though the latter is no mean task, it is one that must be seen within the context of a need for true alteration of the very foundations of our lives.

The white fathers told us: I think, therefore I am.[2] The Black mother within each of us—the poet—whispers in our dreams: I feel, therefore I can be free. Poetry coins the language to express and charter this revolutionary demand, the implementation of that freedom.

However, experience has taught us that action in the now is also necessary, always. Our children cannot dream unless they live, they cannot live unless they are nourished, and who else will feed them the real food without which their dreams will be no different from ours? "If you want us to change the world someday, we at least have to live long enough to grow up!" shouts the child.

Sometimes we drug ourselves with dreams of new ideas. The head will save us. The brain alone will set us free. But there are no new ideas still waiting in the wings to save us as women, as human. There are only old and forgotten ones, new combinations, extrapolations and recognitions from within ourselves—along with the renewed courage to try them out. And we must constantly encourage ourselves and each other to attempt the heretical actions that our dreams imply, and so many of our old ideas disparage. In the forefront of our move toward change, there is only poetry to hint at possibility made real. Our poems formulate the implications of ourselves, what we feel within and dare make real (or bring action into accordance with), our fears, our hopes, our most cherished terrors.

For within living structures defined by profit, by linear power, by institutional dehumanization, our feelings were not meant to survive. Kept around as unavoidable adjuncts or pleasant pastimes, feelings were expected to kneel to thought as women were expected to kneel to men. But women have survived. As poets. And there are no new pains. We have felt them all already. We have hidden that fact in the same place where we have hidden our power. They surface in our dreams, and it is our dreams that point the way to freedom. Those dreams are made realizable through our poems that give us the strength and courage to see, to feel, to speak, and to dare.

If what we need to dream, to move our spirits most deeply and directly toward and through promise, is discounted as a luxury, then we give up the core—the fountain—of our power, our womanness; we give up the future of our worlds.

2. The conventional English translation of French philosopher René Descartes's (1596–1650) Latin phrase *cogito ergo sum*, a fundamental precept of modern Western thought.

For there are no new ideas. There are only new ways of making them felt—of examining what those ideas feel like being lived on Sunday morning at 7 A.M., after brunch, during wild love, making war, giving birth, mourning our dead—while we suffer the old longings, battle the old warnings and fears of being silent and impotent and alone, while we taste new possibilities and strengths.

1977

125th Street and Abomey[1]

Head bent, walking through snow
I see you Seboulisa[2]
printed inside the back of my head
like marks of the newly wrapped akai[3]
that kept my sleep fruitful in Dahomey 5
and I poured on the red earth in your honor
those ancient parts of me
most precious and least needed
my well-guarded past
the energy-eating secrets 10
I surrender to you as libation
mother, illuminate my offering
of old victories
over men over women over my selves
who has never before dared 15
to whistle into the night
take my fear of being alone
like my warrior sisters
who rode in defense of your queendom[4]
disguised and apart 20
give me the woman strength
of tongue in this cold season.

Half earth and time splits us apart
like struck rock.[5]
A piece lives elegant stories 25
too simply put
while a dream on the edge of summer
of brown rain in nim trees[6]
snail shells from the dooryard
of King Toffah[7] 30

1. Capital of the ancient African kingdom of Dahomey (modern-day Benin), one of the main centers of the slave trade. "125th Street": major thoroughfare in the Harlem district of Manhattan, today called "Martin Luther King Jr. Boulevard" and often referred to as "Harlem's Main Street."
2. Another name for the Dahomey hermaphroditic sky deity Mawu-Lisa, whom Lorde glosses in *The Black Unicorn* as "the goddess of Abomey—'The mother of us all' . . . sometimes known as Sogbo, creator of the world."
3. Tight woven braids wrapped with thread.
4. The Dahomey king employed a special sect of female warriors, known as Amazons, who would generally fight behind the men so as to mislead the enemy as to the army's size.
5. In Exodus 17.5–6, Moses strikes the rock at Horeb and produces water for the Israelites, whose thirst had caused them to doubt the presence of God.
6. A tree common in Benin, believed to cure malaria and other diseases.
7. King Toffah (generally spelled "Toffa") reigned in the kingdom of Hogbonu, a region of Benin now called Porto-Novo, from 1874 until his death in 1908.